

SARA FAZELI, PhD

Instructional Designer | Instructional Technology & Online Learning

Canvas LMS Course Design & Quality Standards • Accessibility (UDL/WCAG 2.2) • AI-Enhanced Learning Content • Human-AI Interaction
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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Instructional designer and educator with more than three years of experience with a track record in instructional technology and online learning, building and revising online, Canvas-based courses aligned to measurable outcomes, course design standards, and quality review processes. Experienced applying UDL and WCAG 2.2 accessibility practices, using LMS usage data and learner feedback to identify friction points and drive iterative course improvements. Tracks emerging technologies and digital pedagogy trends to bring instructional innovation and AI-enhanced learning content into online pedagogy for large student cohorts. Google-certified in UX Design, with applied Figma, HTML/CSS/JavaScript, and Git/GitHub experience supporting cross-functional collaboration with instructional technology, IT, and academic stakeholders.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Instructional Design: Canvas LMS course design, configuration, and iterative revision; course and program design standards; rubric-based assessment and quality review metrics; ADDIE/backward design; curriculum mapping; course approval processes; measurable learning outcomes

UX & Human-Centered AI Research: User research; qualitative interviewing; qualitative synthesis; persona development; human-AI interaction; AI-assisted workflow research; prompt-scaffolding design; usability analysis; evaluation criteria

Accessibility & Learner Experience: UDL, ADA, and WCAG 2.2-informed design; alt text and caption-aware media; UI/UX principles applied to online learner engagement; usability analysis; user testing and documentation for course templates and workflows

Collaboration & Communication: Stakeholder and SME communication; cross-functional coordination with international partners and institutional teams; translating complex material for specialist and general audiences; documentation and SOP-style process writing

TEACHING & INSTRUCTIONAL DESIGN EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record / Online Course Designer 2024 – 2026

University of Florida — Gainesville, FL

- Taught and iteratively revised a fully online Canvas LMS course, developing sequenced modules, lectures, media, discussions, quizzes, and rubric-based assignments aligned to measurable course outcomes and course design standards.
- Implemented UDL, ADA, and WCAG 2.2 accessibility practices across course materials, including readable document structure, alt text, and caption-aware media, strengthening accessibility compliance goals.
- Analyzed LMS usage patterns, recurring learner questions, quality review metrics, and qualitative feedback to identify friction points and revise course content, directions, and learner supports, improving engagement and learning outcomes through data- and UX-informed design.
- Reviewed and updated course textbooks and learning materials each semester, resolving access, cost, and currency issues while routing revisions through the departmental course approval process to support consistent, current online course delivery.
- Designed a structured generative AI learning project for 21 student groups, developing prompt-scaffolding guides, phased deliverables, responsible-use expectations, and evaluation criteria to support scalable, AI-enhanced instructional design and clearer learner pathways.
- Designed clear learning pathways, learner-facing instructions, formative assessments, and rubric-based evaluations for diverse undergraduate learners, translating complex interdisciplinary content into accessible, standards-aligned online instruction.

Teaching Assistant, Five Higher Education Courses 2021 – 2024

University of Florida — Gainesville, FL

- Managed LMS workflows, grading, assessment administration, and instructional-material maintenance across online and in-person courses, improving course delivery consistency and reducing faculty coordination burden.
- Developed assignment design, rubric construction, feedback consistency, and accessible digital learning practices guidance; recommended targeted revisions when materials caused confusion or barriers for learners.
- Mentored students across five higher-education courses through one-on-one support, translating complex concepts into plain language and linking feedback to actionable improvement steps that strengthened comprehension and academic performance.

UX & LEARNING RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

UX & Learning Researcher 2024 – Present

Independent Practice — Remote

- Managed an educational UX research study with 12 participants on AI-assisted learning workflows, synthesizing qualitative findings into five learner personas and design recommendations that clarified learner needs and informed UI/UX decisions.
- Developed Figma prototypes for a prompt-scaffolding learning tool, integrating human-centered design, accessibility standards, and user-flow analysis to improve LMS and edtech user experience.

Doctoral Researcher 2021 – 2026

University of Florida — Gainesville, FL

- Conducted a multi-sited ethnographic study drawing on fieldwork, interviews, digital materials, archival sources, and scholarly literature; authored a dissertation awarded the SEM Sound Studies Paper Prize by the Society for Ethnomusicology.

Researcher and Editor 2016 – 2018

Music Museum of Iran — Tehran, Iran

- Co-led documentation and digitization workflows with the Center for World Music, University of Hildesheim, coordinating peer review processes across international partners and institutional stakeholders to support preservation and access to music archives.

EDUCATION

University of Florida — PhD, Ethnomusicology; Graduate Certificate in Women's Studies, 2026

Tehran Art University — MA, Ethnomusicology, 2019

Azad University, Tehran — BS, Industrial Engineering, 2013

CERTIFICATIONS & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- Generative AI in Adobe Creative Cloud: Content Creation — Adobe / Coursera, 2026
- Adobe Captivate for Beginners: Make a Scored Assessment — Coursera, 2026
- Create eLearning Courses with Articulate Storyline 360 — Coursera / Packt, 2026
- Google UX Design Professional Certificate; Google Artificial Intelligence Essentials; Introduction to Generative AI Learning Path — Google/Coursera, 2026
- Designing with the WCAG 2.2 Guidelines; Accessibility for Web Design — LinkedIn Learning, 2025
- HTML Essential Training; CSS Essential Training; Learning JavaScript; React Essential Training; Git Essential Training — LinkedIn Learning, 2025

AWARDS & RECOGNITION

- SEM Sound Studies Paper Prize, Society for Ethnomusicology, 2026
- ACLS Leading Edge Fellowship Finalist, 2026
- Chair, Encounters in Sound Studies Panel, Society for Ethnomusicology, 2025
- "Sounding Freedom," Rising Voices in Ethnomusicology 20.1, 2024